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Korea Transportation Guide

Korea has world-class public transport — once you understand the system, getting around is easy, cheap and fast.

T-money Card — Start Here

The T-money card (티머니 카드) is a rechargeable transit card that works nationwide on all subways, city buses, and most taxis. It's the single most important thing to get on arrival.

Where to buy

- Any convenience store: GS25, CU, 7-Eleven, Emart24
- Incheon Airport arrival hall (after customs)
- Subway station vending machines
- Cost: ₩3,000–5,000 (card deposit included)

Benefits

- Cheaper than single-journey tickets
- Transfer discounts between subway and bus
- Works in all major Korean cities
- Top up at any convenience store or subway machine

 **Tip:** Load at least ₩30,000–50,000 when you arrive. Minimum balance for a subway ride is around ₩1,400. If your card runs out mid-journey, tap at an add-fare machine (잔액보충기) before exiting.



From Incheon Airport to Seoul



AREX — Airport Railroad Express Best Value

The most popular option. Two services run from Incheon Airport Terminal 1 & 2:

- **Direct (직통):** Incheon → Seoul Station in **43 minutes**. ₩11,000. No stops.
- **All-stop (일반):** Incheon → Seoul Station in **66 minutes**. ₩4,850 (T-money). Stops at Gimpo, Hongdae, etc.

Direct (no stops) ₩11,000 (~\$8)

All-stop (T-money) ₩4,850 (~\$3.50)



Airport Limousine Bus Comfortable

Premium buses that go directly to major hotels and neighborhoods in Seoul. Good if your hotel is on the route.

- Takes 60–90 minutes depending on traffic
- Cost: ₩17,000–20,000 depending on route
- Routes shown on boards at arrival hall — look for your destination



Taxi / KakaoTaxi

Convenient but expensive from the airport — heavy traffic on the highway and a toll road fee on top.

- Regular taxi: ₩60,000–90,000 to central Seoul
- Kakao Black (premium): ₩80,000–120,000
- Use only metered taxis from official taxi stands — avoid touts



Seoul Subway

Seoul's subway is one of the world's best — 9 major lines, 300+ stations, signage in Korean/English/Chinese/Japanese, and trains every 2–5 minutes.

Line 1 (1호선)

Line 2 (2호선)

Line 3 (3호선)

Seoul Station, Dongdaemun,
Incheon

Gangnam, Hongdae, Sinchon,
City Hall

Gyeongbokgung, Express Bus
Terminal

Line 4 (4호선)

Myeongdong, Dongdaemun
History Park

Line 5 (5호선)

Gimpo Airport, Yeouido,
Gwanghwamun

Line 6 (6호선)

Itaewon, Mapo, DMC

Line 7 (7호선)

Gangnam, Nowon, Dobongsan

Line 9 (9호선)

Gimpo Airport → Gangnam
(express)

SUBWAY TIPS

- Download **Naver Maps** or **KakaoMap** for real-time subway routes — more accurate than Google Maps in Korea
- Stand on the **right side** of escalators — left side is for walking
- Priority seating (노약자석) is for elderly, pregnant women, and disabled — don't sit there even if it's empty
- Eating on the subway is uncommon and frowned upon — finish your coffee before boarding
- Subway runs approximately 5:30am–midnight. Last trains vary by line.



KTX Bullet Train — City to City

The Korea Train Express (KTX) connects major cities at speeds up to 305 km/h. The most comfortable and reliable way to travel between Seoul, Busan, Daegu, Daejeon and Gwangju.

Seoul → Busan

2h 20min

₩59,800 economy / ₩83,700 first class

Seoul → Daegu

1h 40min

₩43,500 economy

Seoul → Daejeon

50min

₩23,700 economy

Seoul → Gwangju

1h 30min

₩46,800 economy

💡 **KTX Booking:** Book on **Korail** (letskorail.com) or the **Korail Talk** app. Foreign credit cards work. Book at least 3–7 days ahead for popular weekend trains — they sell out. Window seats fill up first.

Taxis



Kakao Taxi (카카오택시)

Korea's dominant taxi app. English available, shows fare estimate before booking, accepts foreign cards. Download before you arrive. Kakao T app — the same as KakaoTalk but transport-focused.

TAXI TYPES & FARES (SEOUL)

- **Regular (일반):** Base fare ₩4,800. Orange or silver cars. Available everywhere.
- **Large (모범):** Premium black vehicles, higher fare (~1.5x), professional drivers. Good for airport runs.
- **Kakao Black:** Premium, English-speaking driver available, flat-rate option. Best for big groups or late nights.
- **Night surcharge:** Fares increase by 20% between midnight and 4am.

Intercity Bus

Express buses (고속버스) are the cheapest way to travel between cities. Slightly slower than KTX but serve many cities the train doesn't reach.

KEY BUS TERMINALS IN SEOUL

- **Seoul Express Bus Terminal (강남)** — buses to Busan, Daegu, Gwangju, Jeonju
- **Dong Seoul Bus Terminal (건대입구)** — buses to east coast cities, Gangneung, Sokcho
- Book online at **kobus.co.kr** or at the terminal
- Prices roughly 40–50% cheaper than KTX for same routes



Transport Korean Phrases

...역이 어디예요?	...yeok-i eo-di-ye-yo?	Where is ... Station?
이 버스 ...에 가요?	i beo-seu ...e ga-yo?	Does this bus go to ...?
어디서 내려야 해요?	eo-di-seo nae-ryeo-ya hae-yo?	Where should I get off?
티머니 충전해 주세요.	ti-meo-ni chung-jeon-hae ju-se-yo.	Please top up my T-money card.
부산까지 한 장 주세요.	bu-san-kka-ji han jang ju-se-yo.	One ticket to Busan, please.
카드 돼요?	ka-deu dwae-yo?	Can I pay by card?

Getting around is just the start

Learn Korean to have deeper conversations and experiences everywhere you go.

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